
Teresa Carreño

1853–1917, VENEZUELAN

Pianist, singer, and composer Carreño was born in Caracas, Venezuela, but left the country with her parents in 1862, spending most of the remainder of her life in the US and Europe. A child prodigy at the piano, she performed her first public concert in New York City before the age of 10. She became a virtuoso of worldwide renown, sometimes referred to as the “Valkyrie of the Piano.” Her career as an operatic soprano began in Europe in the 1870s but was never comparable to her pianistic career. As a composer she wrote chiefly, but not exclusively, for piano. Most of her works were written by 1875, after which she composed only sporadically. She used her influence as a virtuoso to promote the work of the US composer and pianist Edward MacDowell, who was her pupil and friend. Carreño was married four times and had six children.

KEY WORKS: Gottschalk Waltz (piano solo), Op. 1, 1863; Ballade (piano solo), Op. 15, 1867; La Fausse Note (piano solo), Op. 39, 1872; Serenade for String Orchestra, 1895